in epic tales, from Greece to India, prophesying war and violence was commonplace, and that through these the listeners and readers knew in advance who was going to be defeated, who killed. While in the Greek texts such predictions were articulated by seers, heroes, and other such characters, in the Indian epics it was more common to spell out what the stars foretold.

Diviners and soothsayers in ancient India were well versed in this lore and used their knowledge to become powerful. Presumably for this reason, such specialists were not always liked. In specific instances, ascetics were prohibited 'from desiring to secure alms by foretelling the results of portents (like earthquakes) or of bodily movements (such as the throbbing of the eye or arm) or by naksatravidya (astrology) or angavidya (palmistry) or by casuistry.'[54] Such censure did not *always* apply to them, and evidently they were considered acceptable in the royal court of the Mauryas. The *Arthashastra* seems to suggest that the king should appoint as his chaplain (or 'purohita') not only someone whose family and character were exalted and who had thoroughly studied the Vedic texts, but also one who had trained 'in divine signs, in omens and in the science of politics and capable of counteracting divine and human calamities by means of Atharvan remedies.'[55]

By this time, predictions at the time of their birth about the brightness of their future career also formed part of the popular lore about great men. The future glory of the Buddha had been predicted in precisely this way. He was born as 'Siddhartha' in the latter part of the sixth century BCE and, the story goes, it was a sage who first declared at his birth that he would attain greatness. This sage was Asita, a Brahman who was also the teacher of the Buddha's father, Suddodhana. He is supposed to have developed psychic powers and would often spend the day in the world of the gods (the 'deva' world). On one such occasion he encountered the gods engaged in great rejoicing and learnt that Siddhartha Gautama, destined to become the